Dad's Records, Category by Category

A one-page organizer for what exists, where it's kept and who can get to it.

Some of Dad's statements come in the mail and some are online. The insurance papers are in his desk, mostly, and the deed is in a box somewhere in the hall closet.

This page doesn't ask you to read or understand any of it. Go through it with Dad, a category at a time, and for each record write where it's kept, how recent it is and who can get to it. An empty line is fine. It becomes your list of what to look for.

RECORD	WHERE IT'S KEPT	ITS DATE	WHO CAN GET TO IT
Identity and residency papers			
Social Security and income records			
Bank statements, for each account			
Investment account records			
Retirement-account records			
Insurance policies and records			
Property records: the deed to his home, and papers for any other property			
Trust and annuity papers, if he has any			
Notes and paperwork on significant transactions, gifts or transfers			
His spouse's financial records, if he is married			
Care and medical paperwork			

What we haven't located, and who will look

Anything above with an empty line. Put a name next to each.

FOR EXAMPLE No deed in the hall closet box. Dad thinks it may be in his safe deposit box. He'll look the next time he's at the bank.

How statements are kept from here on

Where new statements go as they arrive, on paper or online, and who keeps that current. Describe what your family actually does.

FOR EXAMPLE Paper statements go in the accordion folder, newest in front. The credit union's are online only; Dad saves a copy of each when he does his taxes.

Date of last update, and when we'll look at this page again

How to use it

- Write the date printed on each item, or the month of the most recent statement. If it has no date, write “undated.”
- “Where it's kept” can be a drawer, a file box, a website or a person. Write it the way you'd tell your brother or sister over the phone.
- Leave account numbers, Social Security numbers and passwords off this page. Just say where the record is.
- Don't rewrite or summarize a document here, and don't move one without Dad knowing where it went.

What this page doesn't do

It doesn't explain what any statement, policy, deed or transaction means, and it doesn't say which records Dad's state would ask for or how far back. If you read something you don't understand, that's a question for the company that issued it or for a professional. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know where each of Dad's records is kept, who can get to it, and which ones haven't turned up. The planning interview is the next step: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care. Keep this page beside you while you answer.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Several rows follow the lists of papers that the National Institute on Aging and the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau suggest keeping together. The rest come from the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's working list for this step.

1. National Institute on Aging, Getting Your Affairs in Order Checklist: Documents to Prepare for the Future
2. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness